of the reserved seats will be in South Goa. The BJP is also unsure if they will be able to take all four reserved seats if the quotas come through. Then, there is the pending demand for including the Gouly-Dhangars in the ST category.

An indication of how the BJP could be singed had come in 2024: tribal anger is said to have partly led to its trouncing in the South Goa Lok Sabha seat. But granting quotas also upsets the equilibrium. Part of the government's hesitation had also owed to opposition by other caste groups like the Kshatriya Marathas and the Bhandaris. They had wanted the notification deferred till population data is updated via a caste census, and then rotational reservation rolled out in line with the new numbers.

THE MANY OPTIONS

Earlier, the Centre had delayed the notification upon which the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) can act, foreseeing the issues involved. For instance, the Gouly-Dhangars have sought inclusion in the ST category since the 1980s—they have given the government till August 15 to say yes. But the Registrar General of India and the Union ministry for tribal affairs have rejected the demand. At present, they are in the OBC category. They number only around 25,000, but can tip the scales in many seats due to Goa's micro-sized electorates.

The Gauda, Kunbi and Velip communities—Hindus and Catholics—were added to the ST list in 2003. Smaller groups include the Dubla, Siddi, Naikda, Varli and Dhodia. Quepem, Sangeum, Priol and Nuvem are four seats with a substantial tribal population that may be reserved for STs.

Regarded as Goa's original inhabitants, tribals numbered 149,275 in 2011—6.92 per cent of North Goa's population at 56,606, and 14.47 per cent of South Goa at 92,669. Analyst Yugank Naik calls them a "model of social awakening and emancipation", being politically aware and assertive. "Tribals are the only group in Goa who took to the streets for their rights," he adds. ■

▶ KERALA

A Quick End to the Honeymoon

CM Satheesan takes on all comers, ruffling feathers in his own party and causing discontent among allies



COMING ON TOUGH Kerala chief minister V.D. Satheesan

ARUN KUMAR

By **Jeemon Jacob**

KERALA FACES A REAL DELUGE, a recurring monsoon nightmare since 2017, but both sides of the state's political binary are drowning in troubles writ by their own actions. Congress chief minister V.D. Satheeshan, who outsmarted everyone to get to his chair, may be bringing his honeymoon period to a quick end by opening up too many fronts. His combative, self-willed decision-making—a contrast to his endearing "Pookie CM" image in the public—risks alienating even segments who back him. The CPI(M), licking its wounds after a bruising defeat in the Left's sole remaining citadel, finds itself adrift and still groping for ways to win friends and influence people—including its own cadre.

Both may find succour in the other's predicament. The Left can watch with ironic satisfaction as Satheeshan's own party leaders revolt against his "authoritarian" style. What brought on such a charge? A string of contentious decisions bearing his imprint. As finance minister, he halved excise duty on low alcohol drinks without consulting his party or the larger United Democratic Front (UDF). He also allocated Rs 100 crore for the Rare Earth and Critical